

SAILS ADVISORY

SAILS WORKING DOC · FOR FOUNDERS

The First AE Hire Scorecard.

A working interview scorecard, compensation benchmarks, and 90-day ramp plan for your first Account Executive hire in a B2B SaaS velocity sales motion.

8 PAGES · BY MATT WEISMAN

Why this hire matters more than any other.

If it goes right, you have a repeatable motion. If it goes wrong, you waste six months and \$150K.

Your first AE hire is the single most consequential sales hire you will ever make. Get it right and the next ten hires ramp on a template. Get it wrong, blame the rep, hire again, and watch the same outcome repeat.

The two failure modes

MODE 1 — OVER-HIRE

You hire a senior AE from a brand-name SaaS. They've never built pipeline. They expect inbound. They quit in month four.

MODE 2 — UNDER-HIRE

You hire someone hungry but green. No coaching cadence. No documented motion. They flounder for six months. You blame the hire.

The fix

Hire to your motion, not to a resume. Build the playbook first. Set up the coaching cadence before day one. Pay competitively for velocity sales (1:1 base-to-variable), not enterprise. And evaluate against a written scorecard so every interviewer is calibrated to the same bar.

This doc gives you the scorecard, the comp benchmarks, the ramp plan, and the most common pitfalls. Use it as-is or adapt it to your situation.

What to look for. What to screen out.

The profile that works for first AE

- **2 to 4 years of B2B SaaS sales experience.** Enough to know the basics, not enough to be set in their ways.
- **Velocity-motion experience.** SMB or mid-market. Not enterprise. Fast cycle environments only.
- **Documented outbound chops.** Cold email, cold call, LinkedIn outreach. They've generated their own pipeline before.
- **High activity tolerance.** Can handle 50+ daily activities without burning out.
- **Coachable.** Non-negotiable. You'll be teaching them constantly. If they push back on feedback in the interview, they'll push back at month six.
- **Comfortable with ambiguity.** Some days the playbook will be wrong. They need to roll with it and bring back feedback.

What to screen out

- **Senior AEs (6+ years) from enterprise environments.** They know how to run a process. They don't know how to build one.
- **Reps who can't demo the product live.** If they can't do a back-of-the-envelope demo in the interview, they can't do one with a real prospect.
- **Anyone who talks about "their territory" or "their book."** Those concepts don't exist at your stage. They want structure you can't yet provide.
- **Reps from companies where they never generated their own pipeline.** If marketing always fed them leads, they don't know how to build a pipeline from scratch.
- **Reps with 12-month tenure stints across multiple recent jobs.** Pattern signal.

LOGO PRESTIGE

Less important than you think. A rep who closed \$1.2M ARR at a no-name SMB SaaS often outperforms one who closed \$3M at a famous brand.

TENURE TRACK RECORD

Two-plus years at their last meaningful role. Job hoppers won't ride out the ramp.

A 4-stage process designed to surface fit.

STAGE	FORMAT	WHAT IT TESTS
1. Screen 30 min	Founder or hiring manager. Phone or video.	Basics: prior motion, ACV experience, recent attainment, why they're looking.
2. Sell us 45 min	Candidate prepares a 15-min mock pitch of your product (you send a deck and ICP brief in advance). Then 30 min of Q&A.	Sales instincts, ability to absorb new product fast, coachability when you push back on their pitch.
3. Mock discovery 45 min	You play the prospect. Candidate runs a discovery call cold. Then debrief.	Whether they actually run structured discovery, ask the right questions, handle pushback, know when to advance the deal.
4. Founder fit 30 min	1:1 with founder. No agenda. Honest conversation.	Trust, alignment on stage, willingness to operate in ambiguity. The "would I want to be in the trenches with this person at month nine" gut check.

Total candidate time: 2.5 hours. Total interviewer time: 2.5 hours. Do this over 7-10 days. Don't rush — the cost of a wrong hire is much higher than two extra weeks of process.

Two non-negotiables

- **The mock pitch (Stage 2) must include a curve-ball.** Push back on something they say. Watch how they respond. A coachable rep absorbs and adapts. An uncoachable one defends.
- **The mock discovery (Stage 3) must end with the candidate trying to advance the deal.** If they end the call without an explicit next-step ask, that's the answer to whether they'll do it with real prospects.

Score each candidate against the same 10 dimensions.

1 = poor · 3 = meets bar · 5 = exceptional. Multiply by weight. Total of 100 possible points.

DIMENSION	SCORE (1-5)	WEIGHT	TOTAL
Velocity motion fit SMB/mid-market cycle experience, comfortable with \$2K-\$24K ACVs.	—	x3	—
Outbound demonstrated Can show specific examples of self-sourced pipeline.	—	x3	—
Coachability How they absorbed your push-back in the mock pitch.	—	x3	—
Discovery skill Quality of questions, sequencing, ability to surface real pain.	—	x2	—
Closing instinct Asked for next step explicitly in mock discovery.	—	x2	—
Product absorption speed How quickly they understood your product enough to pitch it.	—	x2	—
Activity tolerance Honest assessment of daily call/email volume they can sustain.	—	x2	—
Tenure track record 2+ years at last meaningful role, no recent job-hopping.	—	x1	—
Comfort with ambiguity Reaction when you describe the unstructured environment honestly.	—	x1	—
Founder fit Trust, alignment, "trenches at month nine" gut check.	—	x1	—
TOTAL OUT OF 100			—

How to read the total

- **80+:** Make the offer. This profile fits your motion.
- **65-79:** Strong candidate with a gap. Identify the lowest-scoring dimension. If it's coachability or velocity fit, pass. Other dimensions can be developed.
- **50-64:** Pass. Don't talk yourself into this hire because you're tired of recruiting.
- **Below 50:** Hard no, regardless of how nice they were.

What to pay your first AE.

For velocity SaaS motions, \$2K-\$24K ACVs, 14-90 day cycles.

COMPONENT	RANGE	WHY THIS NUMBER
Base salary	\$70K-\$90K	Enough to live on while ramping, low enough to keep them hungry for variable.
On-target variable	\$70K-\$90K	1:1 base-to-variable is the velocity standard. Anything higher base ratio attracts coasters.
OTE	\$140K-\$180K	Total at 100% of quota. Market-competitive for the profile.
Quota (annual ARR)	\$700K-\$900K	5x-6x base salary. Industry standard for healthy sales economics.
Accelerator	1.5x-2x above 100%	Critical. A rep who hits 120% should feel it. Otherwise they coast after hitting number.
Draw / floor	None	No safety net on commission. Forces hunter mentality. (Optional ramp draw for first 90 days only.)
Commission rate (typical)	10-12% of ACV	OTE divided by quota. Check the math against your specific numbers.

Common comp mistakes

PAYING SENIOR AE COMP

\$120K+ base for a first AE attracts the wrong profile and creates pressure to hire upward. Don't.

NO ACCELERATOR

A rep at 100% has no reason to push to 120%. Build the lever in from day one.

SOFT QUOTA

5x base is the math. Lower than that and the role isn't profitable. Higher and you can't recruit.

Equity

For a first AE at a pre-Series A B2B SaaS, equity range is typically 0.10% - 0.30% with standard 4-year vest and 1-year cliff. Higher if the rep is taking a meaningful pay cut to join, lower if the comp is at

market.

The first 90 days determine whether the hire works.

Days 1-30 • Product and ICP mastery

First 30 days are about absorbing context, not generating pipeline.

- ☐ Week 1 — Product training. Can demo every core feature.
- ☐ Week 2 — ICP and positioning. Reads every marketing asset, customer interview, playbook artifact.
- ☐ Week 3 — Sits in on 5+ live customer calls (current customers or active prospects).
- ☐ Week 4 — Shadows founder on 3+ live sales calls. Delivers the pitch unaided by end of week.

Days 31-60 • Supervised activity

Running the motion with heavy supervision.

- ☐ Takes inbound leads, every call reviewed.
- ☐ Outbound activity at half-volume (15 calls/day, 25 emails/day).
- ☐ Bi-weekly call reviews with founder or sales leader.
- ☐ First demos by week 6. First closed deal expected by week 8.
- ☐ Activity targets: 30 calls/day, 50 emails/day, 5 demos/week by day 60.

Days 61-90 • Full activity

Reaching full ramp.

- ☐ Full activity: 50 calls/day, 75 emails/day, 8 demos/week.
- ☐ Call reviews drop to weekly cadence.
- ☐ Pipeline coverage: 3x to 4x of monthly quota.
- ☐ Closed-won ARR expectation: at least 25% of monthly quota by day 90.
- ☐ On track to hit 100% of monthly quota by month 6.

What goes wrong (and how to avoid it)

- **No playbook to ramp into.** Build it first, then hire. Reverse this and you lose three months.
- **Founder disappears in week three.** Block 5 hours/week for the rep through day 30. Don't taper down until ramp is on track.
- **Wrong rep profile slipped through.** Trust the scorecard. If they scored under 65, don't talk yourself into it.
- **No coaching cadence.** Weekly pipeline review is not coaching. Real coaching means reviewing recorded calls and assigning specific behavior changes.

When to bring in outside help.

If you're a founder about to make this hire and the playbook isn't documented, the hire will struggle. Build the engine first. Hire second. Ramp third. The sequence matters.

The Build phase of the SAILS engagement produces the hiring profile, the comp structure, the 90-day ramp plan, and the documented playbook the rep will run. The Coach phase then runs alongside the new AE's ramp to ensure they hit 100% of quota by month 6.

If you're about to make your first AE hire (or your first one didn't work and you're trying again), the first step is a 30-minute discovery call. No pitch, no deck. Just an honest conversation about whether SAILS is the right fit.

Book a Discovery Call

30 minutes. No deck. Direct conversation about where you are and what would actually move the needle.

calendar.app.google/x2MYasUSFXEeow459

Other resources

- **Funnel KPI Tracker** — Excel template to track the 5 metrics that predict velocity sales revenue.
sailsadvisory.com/resources
- **Blog** — More writing on velocity sales motions, playbook design, and founder-led sales handoff.
sailsadvisory.com/blog
- **Fit Diagnostic** — 3-minute online diagnostic to see whether SAILS is the right fit for your motion.
sailsadvisory.com/diagnostic